



△ **Tumble-polished** larimar (pectolite) gem

Pectolite

Pectolite is widely found in Canada, England, and the USA, but gem-quality crystals are relatively scarce. Rare faceted stones tend to have internal veils and cloudy areas, and a banded Peruvian variety is sometimes cut *en cabochon*. The type most widely used as a gem is known as larimar, a blue- to blue-green variety found only in the Caribbean. Other forms of pectolite are found in many locations, but none has the unique coloration of larimar (see box, below). Most pectolite jewellery uses silver but, occasionally, high-grade larimar is set in gold.

Specification

Chemical name Sodium calcium silicate | **Formula** $\text{NaCa}_2(\text{Si}_3\text{O}_8)(\text{OH})$ | **Colours** Colourless, white, bluish, greenish | **Structure** Triclinic | **Hardness** 4.5–5 | **SG** 2.8–2.9 | **RI** 1.59–1.64 | **Lustre** Vitreous to silky | **Streak** White | **Locations** Dominican Republic, Canada, England, USA, Greenland, Russia



Larimar specimen | Rough | The swirling patterns and intense colour banding typical of larimar rough material can be clearly seen in this piece.



51.31-carat larimar cabochon

Diamond and sapphire inlays



Polished larimar | Cut | This tumble-polished nugget of larimar features patches of intense colour and angular patterning.



Larimar statuette | Carved | The larimar museum in Santo Domingo, Dominican Republic (see box, below), is home to rough and carved pieces such as this.



Polished beads

Necklace | Set | The subtle, pastel blue colouring unique to larimar, seen in this exquisite bead necklace, is one of the reasons for its popularity.

Lotus flower brooch | Set | This gold brooch is set with diamonds, sapphires, and two larimar stones – of 51.31 carats and 19.72 carats.

The origins of larimar

Central American sea stone

The inhabitants of the Dominican Republic called the gem “blue stone”, believing it came from the sea. It was given its modern name in 1974 by Miguel Méndez, who combined his daughter’s name – Larissa – and the Spanish for “sea” (*mar*), into the word “larimar”. At first, Méndez and his companion found a few stones on a beach, washed into the sea by the Bahoruco River. They followed the larimar trail upstream, and discovered outcrops of the mineral; these formed the basis of the first mine.



Central America A 17th-century map showing the Dominican Republic, where larimar was first discovered.